

Vision in Motion: Representing Landscape in Time

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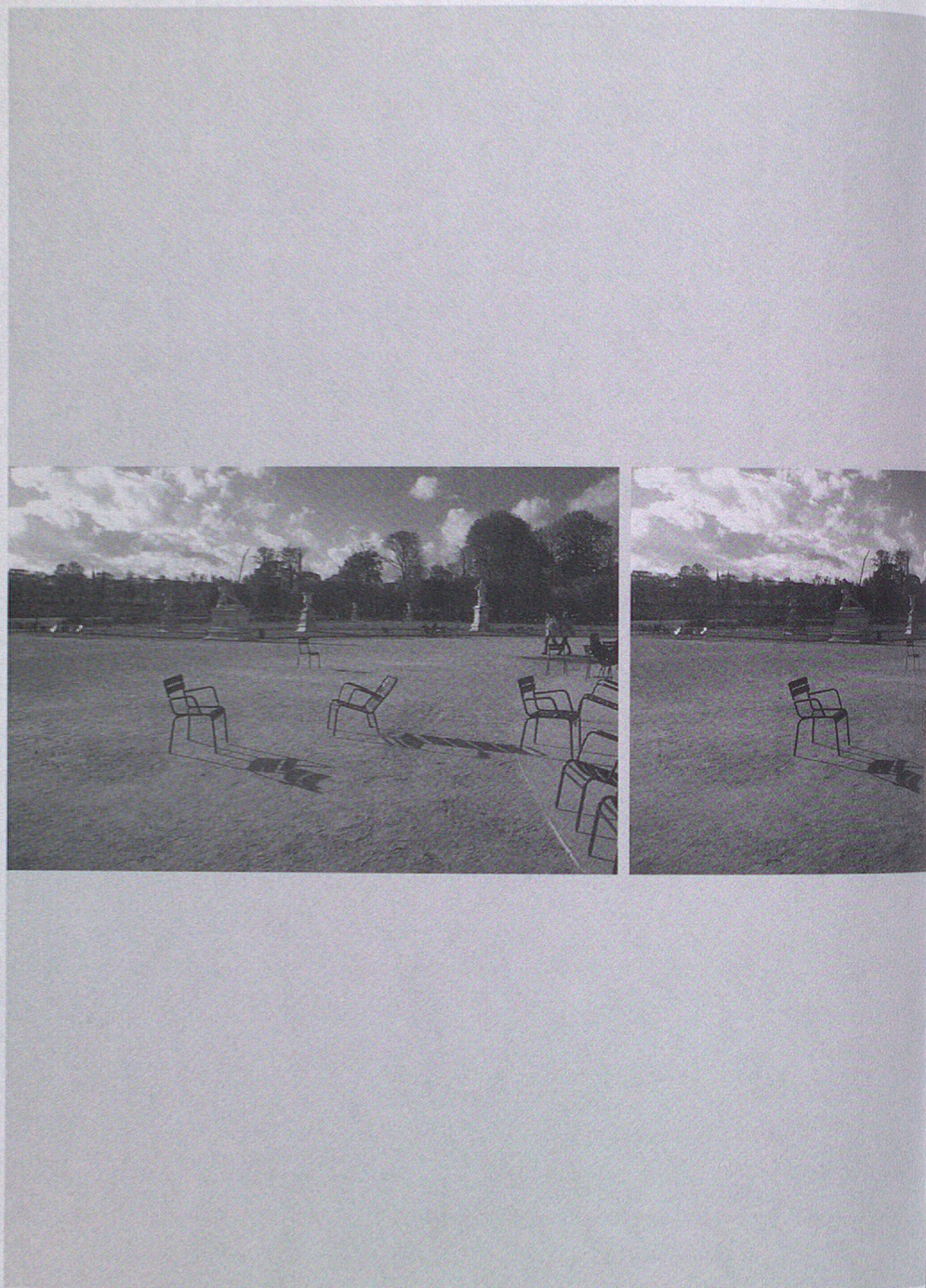


FIG. 1 Tuileries Gardens, Paris

"Form is qualified above all else by the specific realms in which it develops, and not simply by an act of reason on our part, a wish to see form develop regardless of circumstance."

—Henri Focillon

Landscape urbanism is a term that has been coined to depict the study of urbanized landscapes of the second half of the twentieth century. It is, so to speak, the reactive child of all the teachings of our rationalist, functionalist, and positivist forefathers. It is light years away from the inductive thinking of earlier urban designers who drew and built their ideal cities on almost virgin lands. Landscape urbanism is meant first and foremost to decipher what happened in city landscapes of the last decades and to consequently act upon them. It addresses a complex and almost inextricable condition that is strangely recurrent at all four corners of the globe, although at closer look there remain undeniable topographic, climatic, and cultural differences in the patterns that are observed and developed [FIG. 1].

The advent of new media such as digital video has propelled visual research and communication to yet unforeseen levels in the various design disciplines, particularly those dealing with outdoor space. As a result, landscape urbanism, landscape architecture, and urban design are all benefiting tremendously from such progress. In the present context of landscape urbanism in Europe today, the potential impact of the moving image on both urban design and decision-making processes is considerable. It is of particular interest to urban landscape architecture to consider the extent to which such a mode of visual thinking can affect the shaping of future sites [FIG. 2].

THE CITY AS ENIGMA

We have moved from a conscious form-giving model of the city at the beginning of the twentieth century to a self-generated urbanity based essentially on quantitative programs and regulatory norms at the beginning of the twenty-first. The aesthetic of the city at present, if one can still speak in such terms, results at best from an *ad hoc* process, where older landscape identities collide relentlessly with the harsh imperatives of land value, development, productivity, and mobility. The resulting environment is hard to decipher, quite disorienting,



FIG. 2 Affoltern, Zurich

often insensitive, and unpleasant to the eye. Decades of successive upheavals have disfigured the secular qualities of almost every European landscape we know. These environments, when preserved, have been transformed or commodified at best into medieval-style shopping zones with their lot of branded boutiques, arts, craft markets, and flower baskets [FIG. 3].

In their milestone article on the dynamic evolution of the Italian landscape, entitled *Mutamenti del Territorio* ("Mutations of the Territory"), Stefano Boeri and Giovanni Lavarra postulate for an aggregated analysis of the landscape that demarks itself completely from the canons of the established institutional paradigms of representation in the European urban realm.¹ According to them, these canons are principally maintained via the plan (*la visione zenitale aggregata*), and the perspective image (*visione soggettiva e sequenziale*). They postulate, not without a tinge of iconoclastic sarcasm, that there exists a material phenomenology of the European territory based on specific conformities, asperities, and idiosyncrasies. This landscape heritage has until now always been able to digest and transform successive waves of importations into what they call the "European urban phrase." What is most interesting in this thought provoking text is the realization that the European urban landscape is a longstanding moving continuum, a complex flux of interwoven systems and epochs, a syncretism of countless moments compressed into a single space. Boeri and Lavarra claim that the



FIG. 3 Katzen See, Zurich

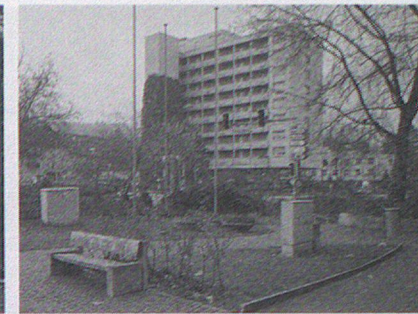


FIG. 4 Affoltern, Zurich

European landscape has self-regulated over centuries the specific acceptance and rebuttal of diverse transformations. If we accept the premise that landscape has undergone such diverse and complex alterations, we need then to decipher the implicit "genetics" of its evolution in order to explicate a vision for the future. And it is precisely this ability to read, integrate, and synthesize such complexities into design thinking that is lacking today.

The urban landscape is the multifaceted mirror of our epoch. For better or for worse, this is the raw material that we work with, and it is particularly important to reflect and act upon it with the proper tools. Scientific and planning models, in all their mathematical beauty, represent but a small part of the picture. There is a need to reinstate a balance between scientific and empirical, heuristic research on the landscapes of cities. Three main forces—degeneration, permanence, and transformation—both physically and ideologically act on the city, repeatedly contradicting each other. Each force, acting on a given site, can be observed synchronously but needs to be understood and engaged in different ways. It is rather ironic that present landscape thinking has chosen to cling exclusively to the notion of permanence, which is the third and much weaker force at stake. This idiosyncrasy can be explained in great part by the still prevalent fascination for the picturesque heritage, but it is also due to a patent absence of alternative modes of thinking and designing [FIG. 4].

Furthermore, urban development is the result of abstract and political processes that are seldom generative of what was expected or told.² The point is not so much to contest or contradict our tools of work but rather to understand how they have been misused, abused, and manipulated in both the design and decision-making processes. We know that the contemporary city is no longer the product of a single thought or plan, the vision of some prince, but rather the diffuse result of successive layers of decisions rarely having anything to do with each other. The established tools of representation influence not only the entire decision-making process and the media, but also subsequently the entire design and building process. The discrepancy between drawings and plans used as tools



FIG. 5 Evry Cathedral, Evry

of commercial and political seduction and the same documents used as a basis for the production and construction of environments has demonstrated concretely the limitations about the way we think of a city and its landscape today. The highly publicized new town of Evry in France is a good case in point; despite the great architectural and landscape architectural talents involved in various aspects of the city project, this new piece of urbanity feels foreign to the place and lacks a definite identity and cohesion. It is as if the sum of the individual parts were not equal to the whole. Generally speaking, the absence of an overview in design and the acute tendency toward a juxtaposition of totally antagonistic programs produces hermetic urban environments that have led to the present paradox: modern cities have literally dispersed and camouflaged the natural substrate of their sites. Many of these substrates have been altered beyond recognition: waters have been covered or diverted, topographies erased or manipulated, forests shredded or fragmented—the list is without end. The fact of the matter is that the acute pragmatism and the short-term goals of current planning trends has remained in great part oblivious to the sensitive physical and visual realms of landscape [FIG. 5].

To this portrait one can add an ever more reduced and questionable production of designs for landscapes. One can say that over half of the urban environments produced escape the hands of architects, landscape architects, and urban designers. Allow the thousand industrial, commercial, and residential zones, having sprouted across France along with their customary road engineering accessories—roundabouts, deviations and so on—to serve as poignant examples. The



FIG. 6 Tableau No. 55, Bustamante

documentary film *Divina Obsesion*, by Volko Kamensky, shows to what extent a single technical street feature such as roundabouts on city peripheries has deeply affected our reading of the common French landscape.³ We have entered a period of blind entropic projection, with its array of unforeseen results. Some theorists have taken on this fatality as a doctrine. The *laissez faire* aesthetic of the contemporaneous city requires, according to them, no vision; it just happens and evolves in an *ad hoc* manner. The denigration of vision and its relegation to the domain of *post facto* appreciation confirms the half-blind aberration we work and live in. Our understanding of remaining natural structures and their inherent potential in rapidly developing urban environments comes more often than not as hindsight. Here, landscape is no longer considered a main structural element but rather as the cherry on the cake, the last green frill on some built tract of land. This extremely reductive attitude in turn affects not only the imageability of a place but also its inherent quality and value [FIG. 6].

TOWARD A NEW UNDERSTANDING

The conclusions to draw from this analysis do not mean, however, that the deconstructed fragmentation of the city should be taken as model. The situationist discourse of the last few years has had no significant impact in the realm of landscape except for its further degradation. Nor does it necessarily mean that we always have to refer to the traces of a given site to legitimate some form of action. Such a retroactive stance, solely based on memory, is in no way a guarantee of quality—all the while denying the possibility for other, more diversified



FIG. 7 Champs Élysées, Paris

means of interpretation. The highly intellectualized analysis of a site and its past is necessarily exclusive and partial, and carries the risk of stifling a given condition. Whether it be the *laissez faire* discourse of chaos theory, the iconoclastic stand of a *tabula rasa* approach to urban design, or the melancholic complaint of better things past, the fact is that these dogmas have still not delivered any satisfactory remedial solutions to the current state of urbanism. It would be preferable, as suggested by Boeri and Lavarra, to accept differentiated readings of the urban landscape, readings which may reveal some inherited qualities from the past but may also be capable of repairing and clarifying

opacities of the present. We need now to reinvent a language of the present, with strong new landscape identifiers, capable of integrating the complexity and contradiction of each place. These actions must respond amongst others to these very landscapes that have been either irremediably altered or effaced by the forces at work. There is a need for a completely re-founded vision of contemporary urban landscapes, a creative gaze capable of providing a clearer understanding and line of action for each place [FIG. 7].

A new way of looking at our urban landscapes could deliver a better, more complete understanding of the multiplicity of phenomena at hand. It could also greatly improve the potential for an appropriate and concerted response to a site. It is therefore important to plead for an open, differentiated, and non-dogmatic reading of landscape, where both past traces and potential futures can be grasped synchronously. A site should be thought of within an evolving self-referential frame, a visual frame meant to qualify and strengthen the natural potential of a city over time. The quest for such a comprehensive vision of landscape is, however, almost impossible to attain with the current means at our disposal. We know that our conventional tools for recording and projecting landscape deliver all but an extremely partial and reductive glimpse of the world.

As in quantum mechanics, where the appreciation of a phenomenon under observation depends entirely on the position of the observer, the subjective point of view should become an integral part of the design process. There must be a new assessment of urban phenomena with respect to how they are planned, perceived,

and experienced. We must question how and why we differentiate and substantiate the modern city the way we do. Having reached the limits of a strictly utilitarian viewpoint, a so to speak "objective" assessment, we are left with a sizeable enigma: how do we explain and appreciate the various urban environments that we have been left with? Can we really live and identify with them? It is necessary, at present, to recreate a topological understanding of the city, capable of revealing what is left of our humanity in the diverse environments that have emerged. We must therefore find a more substantiated way of looking at urban landscapes that is able to articulate such complexity into an understandable whole, easily communicable to the broadest range of people [FIG. 8].

CHANGING VISION

Both vision (that is to say the individual projection on a site) and action (the individual or collective use of an environment) contribute to our understanding of a place. Add to these the forces of nature and topography, and we have landscape. Landscape in general, and urban landscape in particular, is simply the sum total of successive dwelling periods on the land. But the complex blending of our cognitive and conceptual realms has led to a veritable dead end in landscape design. How far from reality can the landscape design tools that we work with be? The gradual withdrawal from landscape as a place to landscape as a piece of paper or a computer screen must be questioned, not only in terms of its conceptual shortcomings but also in terms of the very landscapes that result. The finest discourse in plans, whether layered or simple, cannot hide this inherent absence of site. Beautiful landscapes existed many centuries before cartography was even invented or perfected. These much older landscapes were built and thought out directly on the terrain over years. In the absence of a plan, vision became the guiding force of the project. Techniques such as onsite geometry and measurement, hydrology, construction, and horticulture supplied the necessary support for the site-specific vision at hand. The central question today is whether we are even capable of returning to a site-induced vision. Working on a history of plans is not the same as working on a vision of the land. We need to reconsider the primacy of vision over plan, a vision in motion, far removed from the established canons, capable of reflecting and inflecting upon the complex urban realm.

A better integration and understanding of contemporary visual thinking in the early design process, with its direct and indirect correlation in project development and communication, could contribute significantly to this field. Such a vision could concern not only the creative process in urban and landscape design but also the entire chain of decisions leading to the understanding and approval of a specific project. This new way of looking probably lies at the very margins of our habitual conceptual frameworks, where the actual blending of different times in space produces a new dimension. The tool of digital video, combined



FIGS. 8, 9 Porte d'Ivry, Paris

to some extent with the more classical means of topographic and architectonic representation, would enable one to formulate such a synthetic vision of a site, where the relativity of time, space, and motion are all present. The compression of these aspects into a single gaze would, in fact, provide the basis for a four-dimensional understanding of landscape. This new tool could deliver an almost immediate assessment of very complex settings, redefining completely our art of observation [FIG. 9].

LANDSCAPE IN MOTION

It is important to reconsider the perceptual limitations that pertain to landscape thinking in general. Why, for instance, has movement remained so marginal in our visual and sensitive assessment of urban environments? Aren't the fleeting sounds of the city just as significant as the tweet of a bird in our appreciation of a given place? It is now possible to imagine a new form of thinking that can integrate the travelling continuum of space and time, rather than present a series of immutable frames in our understanding of landscape. This means that the very tools of observation we are accustomed to are to be replaced by new ones that are more in tune with the way that we apprehend today's reality. The subject of digital landscape video has emerged in recent times as the ideal tool for such complex observations. It is slowly emerging as a genre of its own, distinct from the video art piece and the musical clip. Landscape video is neither filmic nor artistic, holding an argumentative discourse about site-specific qualities and events that are neither staged nor planned. The video material that is gathered shows samples of a place without cosmetics; its content is, for that matter, extremely raw and potent. In landscape video everything can be blended together indiscriminately—beauty spots can be seen next to no-man's lands. The traditional depiction of a place dissolves inevitably into a broader vision of urban and natural interrelationships and continuities [FIG. 10].

An aerial video over a neighborhood shows demonstratively, in the most intricate visual detail, the main structural framework of a landscape. It has the



FIG. 10 Pont National, Paris



FIG. 11 Nuclear Treatment Plant, La Hague, France

great advantage of revealing the specific identity of a site where houses and streets are immediately recognizable, and rivers and woods can be reconsidered. The image is almost immediate and true to the place, all the while integrating different times and movements in order to show its continually changing facets. Different seasons can be juxtaposed on a given site; transformations and alterations over decades can be compiled and visualized. A landscape seen in a variety of speeds and motions introduces a strong sense of relativity to our understanding of established identities. Recording behavior at different times of day reveals the multifaceted complexity of our cultural environment. What has systematically been called the impoverishment of landscape could now be understood as a form of diversification and enrichment [FIG. 11].

Landscape video also operates a transformation on the audience; the immediate recognizability of the images changes the perception of the viewer, as the video mirrors what one may witness day to day. It is this very act of reflecting that transforms the common gaze of inhabitants into an active, critical viewpoint. Offering a new visual understanding of even the most banal urban environments, this tool can be used critically to change both habits and mentalities. Different than the artistic photographs of similar places, video depicts a continuum rather than a series of frames, and can thus liberate itself entirely from the burden of the still. Here the "sightly" and "unsightly" blend into an overall landscape image, taking away from even the most beautiful vistas some of their splendid isolation. A five-minute presentation about a given site incorporates critical amounts of information and argumentation available, via the pervasive medium of the screen, to a much broader range of people.

Video is becoming a new genre in landscape. A new post-doctoral research program based in Hanover, entitled "Micro Landscapes," under the direction of Brigitte Franzen and Stefanie Krebs, received substantial funding from the VW Foundation in its aim to pinpoint the importance of new dynamics and movement in contemporary landscape design, including the tool of video.⁴ Stefano Boeri pursues his work on landscape video with his proposal for the 2003



FIG. 12 Le Landemer, Normandy

Venice Biennale entitled *Border Device(s) Call*, exhibited at the Institute for Contemporary Art in Berlin, in which he uses video, amongst other media, to depict a route from Berlin to Venice to Jerusalem.⁵ My office in Zurich has produced landscape projects in Italy and Switzerland that integrate video not only as a tool of observation but also as a tool of design synthesis.⁶ The resulting projects have been used in a variety of important decision-making processes, and it is clear that this new form of vision is beginning to have an impact on the way that we shape the landscape [FIG. 12].

Landscape design teaching at several schools in Europe has integrated video as a tool of observation. Both the University of Hanover in Germany and the ETH in Zurich, Switzerland, have gone so far as to create a specialty in this field, training young generations of designers in this new form of visual thinking. They are exploring how video analysis can also influence design development. In the autumn of 2002, the ETH staged a joint exercise on urban landscape design and video on the Kasern Areal of Zurich, showing the correlative potential of video works in design.⁷ The post-graduate program in landscape design at the ETH, inaugurated in 2003, makes it mandatory to correlate the video tool with design. It requires students to think differently and to better incorporate temporal and spatial considerations in their work [FIG. 13].

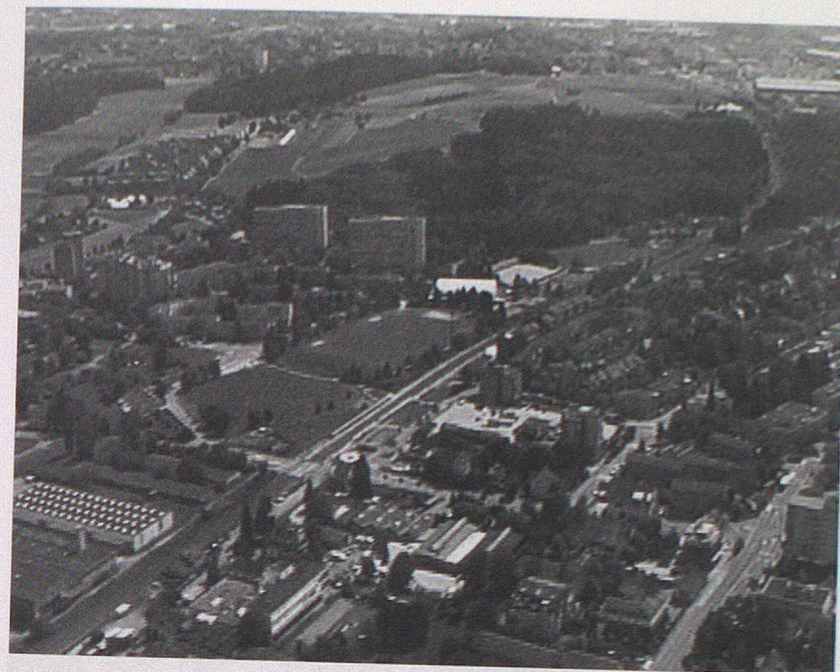


FIG. 13 Aerial view of Affoltern, Zurich

THE SPACES IN BETWEEN

Our way of seeing the landscape has been considerably altered by the various forms of movement that we presently experience through a site.⁸ The moving picture frame, the rolling motion of a car or train, the dashing takeoff of an airplane—all entitle us to question a visual tradition that we have grown to accept, one that has accustomed us to an understanding of landscape through a series of fixed frames and vistas. In light of the discussion on landscape and movement, the French historian Michel Conan recently produced a thought-provoking essay on the premises of the static foundations of landscape scenography.⁹ He argues that the art of the picturesque forwarded a static understanding of landscape where movement was absent, or at least not acknowledged as such. The picturesque landscape was experienced rather as a succession of immobile scenes, as in the example of the romantic promenade of Ermenonville designed by the Marquis René de Girardin, which did not incorporate movement as a significant part of its landscape experience. Referring to the French philosopher Henri Bergson, Conan suggests that a voyage through the landscape could only be understood as a succession of immobile scenes lending themselves to memory and aesthetic interpretation. Any movement in between these successive "immobilities" conferred no sentiment of landscape whatsoever. If this particular interpretation of landscape thinking has transcended into our times, as



FIG. 14 Aerial view of Affoltern, Zurich

epitomized by tourism, we can ask ourselves what the black holes in between the scenes really signify, and to what extent they are not in fact part of the overall key to a new way of thinking and looking [FIG. 14].

Why should the black holes, the in-between scenes of landscape beauty, be of such interest to us? Is it not preferable to remain true to polite society and espouse the notions of landscape beauty inherited from our forefathers? The fact is that we travel daily through a multitude of unexplained black holes. They have become the dominant feature of peripheries and urbanized countries, as in many examples of the Swiss *Mittelland*. We need to consider these long non-entities as probably equally significant as the most celebrated vistas of the Alps. These black holes require a long process of aesthetic acceptance. They need more time and memory to decant their specific identity and to operate a veritable change in our appreciation of them. Numerous artists have attempted to integrate such places into their work, and it is rather ironic that these unplanned and nameless landscapes have achieved suddenly such a high level of aesthetic fashionability. In the case of Switzerland, photographic studies on the Zurich suburbs by the Swiss artists Peter Fischli and David Weiss, and landscape images of Affoltern by the Swiss photographer Georg Aerni, are but a few examples of



FIG. 15 Zuriberg Park, Zurich

works that contribute toward the pictorial integration of such nondescript places.¹⁰ The French artist Jean-Marc Bustamante, with his *tableaux* of half-destroyed landscapes in residential areas of Catalonia, further epitomizes the visual acceptance of this *fait accompli*. But this artistic approach implies two major risks: the first is the unabashed aesthetic consecration of the urban production of the last decades that has in fact negated the very idea of spatial composition; the second is the pursuit of static picture framing, which denies the notion of movement and flux inherent to such landscapes. The works of these artists are veritable *tableaux* or *vedutas*, in the strict sense of the word. They describe these very ugly and banal places in their finest intricacies, and tend to make us accept them as such, after the fact. We have reached a point where we can probably learn quite a lot from these new topologies, but we must also question our contemporary vision of landscape in all its picturesque and static might, to reinvent a grammar of visual sensations that enables us to better understand and act preventively [FIG. 15].

Urban landscapes have in great part become *sui generis* environments—that is to say that sites are no longer composed as such, but rather produced and transformed by abstract rules and regulations. These blind “after the fact”

environments—call them landscapes if you will—require both discernment and an exquisite intuition to make any kind of sense out of them. The tools used to decipher the production of contemporary cities must engage us on the path of a renewed conquest of urban space and natural structures. Urban landscapes today are generally decomposed and fragmented, and we need to identify the modes of representation that have led to such inadequacies. By acquiring new tools with which to question city landscapes through different conformities, and learning from the so far hidden parts of the urban portrait, it is possible to understand the very limits of our knowledge. Knowing and accepting these limits will undoubtedly foster new forms of empirical investigation, as suggested by Michel Foucault in his text on the limits of representation.¹¹ This will bring us to the threshold of a vision capable of transcending the present condition, drawing on unforeseen priorities that may enable us finally to think and compose urban landscapes anew.

Notes

1. Stefano Boeri and Giovanni Lavarra, "Mutamenti del territorio," in Alberto Clementi, ed., *Interpretazioni di paesaggio* (Rome: Meltemi editore, 2002), 96–106.
2. The recent suburbanization of French landscapes has led to a variety of site interpretive theories. Among these is Sébastien Marot's latest book on the topic of "suburbanism." Here Marot postulates a complete role reversal between site and program, where site becomes somehow endowed with the capacity to yield a regulatory idea for a project. See Marot, *Suburbanism and the Art of Memory* (London: AA Publications, 2003).
3. Volko Kamensky, *Divina Obsession*, Germany 1999, 16mm, color, Magnetton, 27:30 min.
4. Brigitte Franzen and Stefanie Krebs, *Mikro-Landschaften, Studien zu einer dynamisierten Kultur der Landschaft* (Hannover, Germany: VW Stiftung, 2003).
5. Stefano Boeri, *Border Device(s) Call*, in the exhibition Territories, Kunst-Werke—Institute for Contemporary Art, Berlin, June 1–August 25, 2003.
6. Christophe Girot and Mark Schwarz, *Feltre, Imagine, Imagini, Imagina* (Zurich: Vues SA, 2001). Christophe Girot and Mark Schwarz, *Die Nordküste, Affoltern* (Zurich: Vues SA, 2003).
7. The project under the direction of Christophe Girot was led jointly by the ETH Landscape Design Lab under the supervision of Julian Varas, and the Landscape Media Lab under the supervision of Jörg Stollmann and Fred Truniger.
8. See Christophe Girot, "Movism," in *Cadrages 1, Le Regard Actif*, ed. Christophe Girot and Marc Schwarz (Zurich: GTA Carnet Video, Professur für landschaftsarchitektur, NSL, ETH Zürich, 2002), 46–53. The text first appeared in the proceedings of the Herrenhausen Congress of 2001. It was subsequently integrated into the GTA, ETH publication.
9. Michel Conan, "Mouvement et métaphore du temps," in Philippe Pulaouec Gonidec, *Les temps du paysage, Paramètres* (Montréal: Les Presses de l'Université de Montréal, 2003), 23–35.
10. Peter Fischli, and David Weiss, *Siedlungen, Agglomeration* (Zurich: Ed. Patrick Frey, 1993). Georg Aerni, *Studie Öffentliche Räume Affoltern*, Amt für Stadtebau Zürich, 2003.
11. "Il n'est sans doute pas possible de donner valeur transcendentale aux contenus empiriques ni de les déplacer du côté d'une subjectivité constituante, sans donner lieu, au moins silencieusement, à une anthropologie, c'est à dire à un mode de pensée où les

limites de droit de la connaissance (et par conséquent tout savoir empirique) sont en même temps les formes concrètes de l'existence, telles qu'elles se donnent précisément dans ce même savoir empirique." Michel Foucault, "Les limites de la représentation," *Les mots et les choses* (Paris: Ed. Gallimard, 1966), 261.